

Academic Writing

Lesson 2: Passive



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

Passive: Task 1



Change these sentences into **passive**. Compare with the active: 1) which is more suitable? 2) If passive, would you include the agent?

1. **Scientists will soon develop a vaccination for the Ebola virus.**
2. **Many politicians continue to debate the costs and necessity of net zero.**
3. **This essay will analyse the key challenges facing governments about engaging citizens with climate change.**
4. **Academics are unable to reach a consensus about on definition of intersectionality.**

1.



A: Scientists will soon develop a vaccination for the Ebola virus.

Or:

B: A vaccination for the Ebola virus will soon be developed.

Or:

C: A vaccination for the Ebola virus will soon be developed by scientists.

B is probably the most suitable. We assume scientists will do it: who else?

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2.



A: Many politicians and scientists continue to debate the costs and necessity of net zero.

Or:

B: The costs and necessity of net zero continues to be debated.

Or:

C: The costs and necessity of net zero continues to be debated by politicians and scientists.

A or **C** probably. Since this issue is widely debated by different groups, you may want to specify which groups.

If keeping the agent, then active might be better: A is 14 words, C is 15, which might be a factor also.

If this is a topic sentence, however, then passive may be better, as it focuses on the idea rather than the people involved.

3.



A: This essay will analyse the key challenges facing governments about engaging citizens with climate change.

Or:

B: The key challenges facing governments about engaging citizens with climate change will be analysed.

Or:

C: The key challenges facing governments about engaging citizens with climate change will be analysed in this essay.

A is the most suitable: as a Thesis Statement, the focus should be on the essay.

4.



A. Academics are unable to reach a consensus about on definition of intersectionality.

Or:

B. A consensus on the definition of intersectionality cannot be reached.

Or:

B. A consensus on the definition of intersectionality cannot be reached by academics.

B is probably the most suitable & saves words. Who else defines academic terms?

Passive: Task 2



What is more important: The event/ideas, or the agents/people involved? Why?

1) The vaccine was approved after extensive clinical trials.

The approval & its conditions matter, not who signed off.

2) The Bank of England raised interest rates in response to inflation.

A specific institutional actor made a decision; that decision-maker is the point.

3) Global temperatures have risen by over 1°C since pre-industrial levels.

The phenomenon; also, there is no agent here (nobody can 'rise' something).

4) Local residents opposed the development on environmental grounds.

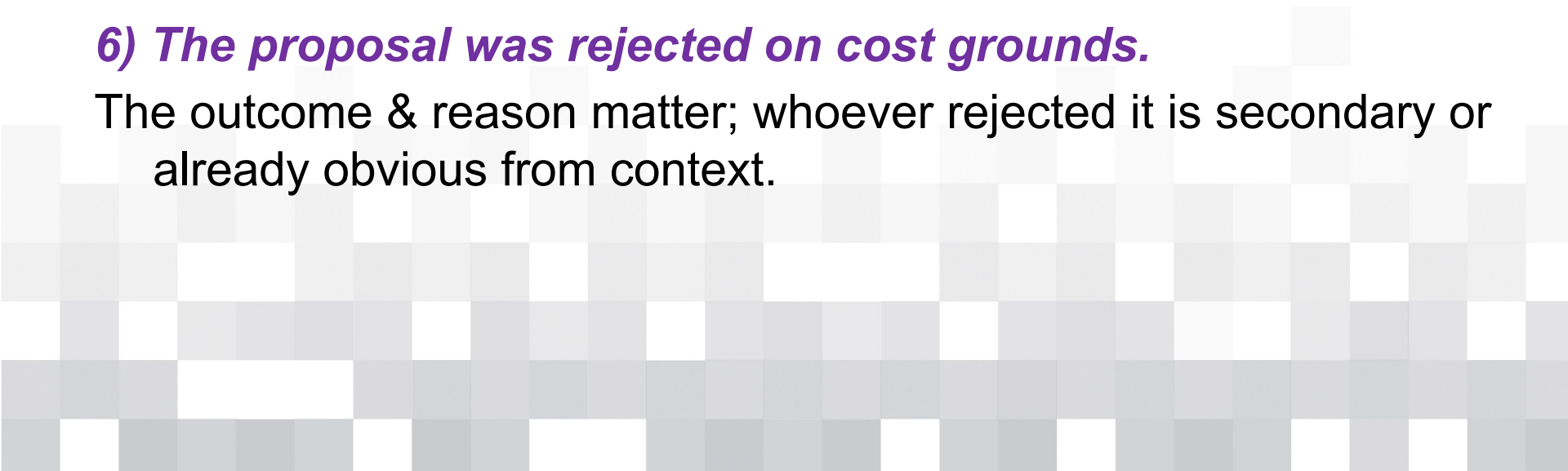
The agent's stance/action is exactly what's being reported.

5) Researchers at LSE identified several important trends.

Credit/attribution to a specific team matters, e.g. for citation or originality claims.

6) The proposal was rejected on cost grounds.

The outcome & reason matter; whoever rejected it is secondary or already obvious from context.

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Passive: Task 3



Read the two paragraphs, one active and one passive. Which is more suitable & why? What other uses of passive can you see?

Answer:

The passive is more suitable. The paragraph outlines a process; therefore, to avoid mentioning the agent (“I”), the passive must be used.

Usually, you will not have so much passive in a paragraph – the best academic example would be in your **methodology** section, when you present your **methods**.

So, how often in a paragraph do you think the passive might appear? Discuss.

Passive: Task 4



How often in a paragraph do you think the passive might appear?

Complete Task 4 before we discuss.

Answers

1: Use of the passive here in the topic sentence allows the writer to foreground “ICT”, the topic of the paragraph.

2: The agent (“technology”) is dropped because it’s been established earlier and is also mentioned later; it does not need repeating.

3: Passive here replaces “as we can see”, thus remaining objective. Looks academic and detached.

How often do passives appear?



It depends – but usually there are around 0-3 passive sentences in a developed paragraph. Sometimes there are more in **methods** sections, or if you are writing **explanations**.

Passives most frequently appear in the middle of paragraphs **but** are also very suitable for **topic sentences** and/or **concluding sentences**.

Passive **topic sentences** allow you to focus on the idea/issue rather than anything else, making the topic clear.

Passive **concluding sentences** allow you to hedge (write carefully) & look objective. Since concluding sentences often contain your opinion, this is useful.

Passive: Task 5



We can see that...

It can be seen that...

We discovered (that)...

It was discovered

Everybody knows (that)...

It is widely/well known

I recommend (that)...

It is highly/strongly recommended

I argue (that)...

I will be argued

You can assume (that)...

It can be assumed

People think (that)...

It is widely believed

Drafting



You have the remainder of the lesson to continue working on your draft for your assignment.

